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Randy Brecker

Randy Brecker was born in the Philadelphia suburb of Cheltenham on November 27, 1945. He has become the prominent trumpet stylist of his generation, displaying his versatility with The Brecker Brothers, the Thad Jones-Mel Lewis Orchestra, and leading his own ensembles.

Randy was interviewed via Zoom on December 12, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and boy am I pleased to have Randy Brecker with me today. You're in Long Island, is that correct?

RB: That's right. Easthampton.

MR: Yeah. And I'm up at Hamilton College in Clinton, New York. I'd like to do a little introduction but you've done too many things. So I have the *All Music Guide to Jazz*. Now this is 25 years old but here's what it says about Randy Brecker. "Randy Brecker is essentially a fine hard bop trumpet soloist, but one versatile enough to fit into nearly any setting including the pop world, funk bands, and electronic fusion." Anything you'd like to add?

RB: Well it's just that it's not that hard to fit into other genres as some people think. You know I just came up listening to a lot of different styles of music, being from Philly, which was a potpourri of all different styles of music, musicians, it was wonderful to see that. And I grew up with that mindset and with the goal of kind of I guess being a freelance musician in New York, for lack of a better way to put it.

MR: Um hum. The idea of hearing — you were born in '45 — maybe 1955 there is so much going on in the jazz world, was there an AHA moment for you that — a person or an LP that really propelled you into the career?

RB: Well that's a good question. Like I said, my father was a semi-professional pianist, very good songwriter/singer, knew a lot of musicians in Philly and there were jam sessions at the house. And the level was really pretty damn high. He had a great record collection. By luck our next door neighbor was a fine tenor player and his sister was a good jazz singer, and people would come over generally. There was a very good trumpet player named Bobby Mojica who had a good career in Detroit as a trumpet player, also was a businessman but he was a great trumpet player. Clifford Brown was alive and well in Philly during those years actually, and he was the talk of the town always. They had a kind of home base in Philadelphia and played there quite a bit. So I just grew up with it. And I don't know if there was an AHA moment because I always — if anything I tried to

get interested in other things because it seemed like the music life so to speak was rather up and down.

MR: How did you know that?

RB: Well just by seeing where musicians played and being on the scene and seeing it was a rough life. Unbeknownst to me though, going back on it, a lot of the Philly cats, who I saw — and I don't remember the name of the place — there were Sunday afternoon jam sessions in South Philly with some of these names you might know, maybe you wouldn't, names like Vince Montana; Buddy Savitt, tenor player; Vince was a vibist. John Bonnie, alto saxophone, local cats. And I would always wonder myself, gee, they're playing here, they probably make fifty bucks, how do they make a living? And unbeknownst to me at the time all these guys were very successful in the local recording business and they had started a lot, they worked with eventually Gamble & Huff and was one huge — I don't know consortium I guess of guys that were producing records, pop records, R&B, really disco records, a lot of the birth of disco in a way it was through these guys. I had no idea at the time. But upon reading about the Philly history on its website and it said "the most listened to tenor player in the world" and I had just known that he had played with Woody Herman, that's John Bonnie, and was a great player in that style, and the Lester Youngish, a little more modern style. But here they were on all these rock & roll records. I didn't know that until way later. It's really interesting.

MR: Let me go back because you froze up for a minute when you said who was the most listened to tenor player.

RB: Oh I'm sorry, I guess, I hope I have a better connection, his name was Buddy Savitt.

MR: Okay you mentioned that already.

RB: Yeah. And he died pretty young I think, at 52 or 53. Wonderful player though. He'd played with — I guess his main claim to fame was he took Stan Getz's place with Woody Herman. But lo and behold, like I said, I had no idea. In fact I found a record with all these cats on it where it's kind of a comedy record where somebody's narrating and they're swinging along a couple choruses of blues, and somebody's saying "here's the way we want to play," and then a couple of choruses later, "and here's the way we have to play" and then they go and do an R&B, and then back and forth as the whole record. But they were on a lot of hit records and I guess that had a big influence subconsciously, even though I didn't know they were doing that. It's kind of funny that I didn't at that time.

MR: May I ask how long your father lived and did he — was he able to see the success that you had as a musician?

RB: Yeah he was. He was a lawyer by trade and worked generally for a friend of his whose name was Max Raab who was a blouse maker and had a very successful business so he

ended up being his legal counsel and Max Raab also sponsored concerts. He was a real jazz fan. So dad — it's hard to describe — he would consciously try to discourage both me and Mike from the music business because it was so unstable and he was afraid it would be hard to make a living. But once we caught on so to speak — man he was our biggest fan. You know he'd go up to everybody and say, "You heard of the Brecker brothers? I'm the Brecker father." And, you know, it was embarrassing.

MR: How did he feel about you leaving school to go gigging?

RB: Well it was that same thing — I left school with the intent of coming back actually. You know I went to Indiana University, and part of it was just happenstance. I went to Indiana University from 1963 to 1966. And in 1965 our big band and our sextet won the Notre Dame Jazz Festival. That was what we all would shoot for every year. The judges — well I just remember one judge was Clark Terry you know. And he gave me a trumpet award and part of our prizes if we took it, and we did take this, we were awarded a 16-week State Department tour in the Middle East and Asia. They were — that facet of the government was actually very proactive then. They had sent Duke Ellington on a similar tour, and we actually followed in his path and Buddy Rich had been on a tour. So off we went and in February of 1966, for four months. And it was fascinating. We heard so much amazing music — just to see that world and what was going on behind the scenes and in front of the scenes for a, you know, 18-, 19-year-old kid, it just shaped the rest of my life. And the band was fantastic. We were really a pro band, sounded really good.

MR: It's interesting that you've spent some significant time in Europe and in fact very recently is that correct?

RB: Well ever since then because that summer I ended up spending the whole summer in Europe. I'll just mention this briefly, you might have known about it or maybe not but, and this was total coincidence but it also was instrumental in helping my career along. When the tour was over we noticed in *DownBeat* that it was an international jazz competition in Vienna. And it turns out it was the only time this was held, 1966. So several of us made our way from Athens. I think that's where the tour dropped us off, to Vienna. I remember my parents showed up, they wanted to see me after the four months, and it looked like it was going to be fun. The judges were Art Farmer, Cannonball Adderley, J.J. Johnson, Ron Carter, Mel Lewis, and Joe Zawinul. It was put together by Friedrich Gulda, a wonderful Viennese pianist. So man it looked like, pretty exciting. And the unusual thing was, and I've mentioned this several times, there were maybe 200 young musicians at this thing going through semi-semi finals, semi-finals, and then the finals. So we were there about ten days, maybe twelve days, in a youth hostel. So this is where I met a lot of other young musicians my age. People like — unknown then — we were all teenagers: George Mraz, Miroslav Vitous, Jan Hammer, Claudio Roditi, Joachim

Kuhn, James Williams, Franco Ambrosetti, Eddie Daniels, and I'm leaving out a lot of people that became famous in Europe. So this was really instrumental in all our development. We got to play together a lot and meet the judges, pal around, and when I moved to New York I didn't quite finish but I went to NYU for a semester and then I kind of got enveloped into the work scene. It was a lot of work back then and I had met Thad and I mean Mel, and Mel asked me to join his big band, and Ron was calling me for gigs, so it couldn't have been a better scenario. Miroslav and Mraz came to town shortly thereafter, as did Jan, we played together. So it's kind of like —

MR: It's kind of like a fairy tale if you ask me.

RB: Yeah. I have to pinch myself looking back. I'm sure we all felt the same way, it was just perfect timing for that. And lo and behold that was the only time — now there are other festivals in Europe, particularly there's one in Israel. But that was the only time they did that in Vienna. It was just perfect for all of us.

MR: So I was at Fredonia in the late 60s, early 70s and we wore out the Blood, Sweat & Tears records. And I'm curious, was it a hard decision to leave that band after the first record, even though you went with Horace Silver, is that correct?

RB: That's correct, yeah.

MR: Can you remember your thinking at the time?

RB: Well my thinking was, and I remember this really clearly, that I needed to play more. And in Blood, Sweat & Tears I also learned a lot from, particularly from doing the first record. "The Child is the Father to the Man" was produced by John Simon who was a very bright young guy who had produced Bob Dylan and had a lot of success in production and really knew how to do those kind of records. Studio technique. Double tracking the horns. If he wanted you to sing in tune, I'd never seen this, he had Steve Katz [performs vocal exercise] somehow just doing it, things like that that really worked. And he double tracked himself singing. In the background he had all these tricks that I didn't take notes but I was watching him very carefully because in my head, well maybe some day I'll be doing a record like this. So I learned an amazing amount about how to build a rock record as you have it — from the bottom up and just the techniques. But at the time, and they were great arrangements, Freddy Lipsius' arrangements, the band was great. I learned so much about the business just by seeing how many thousands and thousands of kids, you know, loved rock & roll music, pop music, you know I lived a little insular life I suppose in jazz in New York where you had to pull people into the club, making five or ten dollars a night sometimes with the Duke Pearson Big Band or Clark Terry's band. That's about how much those gigs would pay at the Half Note. And it was a shock to go out to California and next thing I know I'm playing for thousands of young people kind of had my background so to speak. So it was a difficult decision but

when Horace called. I really wanted to play. I only got to play one solo a night and it was mostly reading horn parts. And I thought I'd gotten enough out of it. And they were going to add a lead singer named David Clayton Thomas. They begged me to stay, they liked what I did, but I said — Al Kooper — we had a band meeting and he didn't like the idea of adding another singer so he quit and at the same time I announced that I was going to join Horace Silver. My last words to them were: "I don't think you guys will ever make it without Al Kooper." And the tough part, and I'll say this honestly, was after the record came out, their second record and it sold nine — no eleven million copies — it was number one for a year, won the Grammy of the year award, their salaries went up like 5,000 percent. I mean and I had to talk my friend Lew Soloff — it was funny, the day before I left I was doing a Joe Henderson big band rehearsal and Lewey was next to me and I explained the situation, I said, "Listen man, I need somebody to cover me or just take the gig, I'm leaving Blood, Sweat & Tears and it pays like a hundred dollars a week whether you work or don't, it's a salary." And he didn't really want to do it. In fact they had asked him previously. But by the end of the rehearsal I talked — "Look, they're going to go in the studio" I just had him talked into doing it. So begrudgingly he took the gig. Two months later their salaries went up to like five thousand a week. I'm making two fifty a week with Horace.

MR: You know you're pushing a button with me because I was in a group that was fairly successfully locally and doing gigs, and the producer wanted us to get a lead singer who just stood there and sang — you know like a lead singer. And we just resisted the heck out of it. And the difference in the story was our salary never went up five thousand percent.

RB: Yeah it was a funny time. And Lew and I would take trumpet lessons and had been doing that for a while with Edward Truetel in New Jersey. We'd take a bus to his house. Then Lewey started picking me up in a limo you know, cackling all the time. And like I said I was making two fifty a week and Horace had left out of the deal that he took taxes out. I'll never forget these figures, so it was really $147.50 a week and I had to pay my hotel out of that.

MR: How much older — can you recall how much older was Horace Silver than you at the time?

RB: Well he was in his — I was — let me see how old was I — 21 or so, and he was in his 40s. He was around twenty years — but you know it was a fantastic band — Billy Cobham fresh out of the Army on drums, John B. Williams who was a student of Ron Carter's then but he was a great bass player and still very active, and the great Bennie Maupin on tenor saxophone. So I couldn't have asked for more — and the band — and I really developed quickly in that kind of circumstance on the other side of the coin.

MR: Did it help your compositional approach to play in that band?

RB: I think it did because Horace had a way of turning his life experience, particularly his travel experience, into music. So you might get a tune called "Tokyo Blues" that has some kind of harmonic influence, or women that he had met along the way, or things that happened to him, "Song for my Father" you know written for his father. He had a way of interpreting his life's experience into music. And he also was very influential to me in that as a hobby, well it wasn't really a hobby because he started utilizing lyrics to his tunes so in his spare time on the buses or on the vans he was writing lyrics that he utilized. So I took that to heart too and started writing lyrics. He also was very — he knew what he wanted from a soloist on certain tunes. I mean he was very active in coaching us on certain tunes where he just wanted a funky solo, not many notes. On other tunes we could play what we wanted but on specific tunes he'd get mad if we played too long or we played too many notes. I remember there was a record we did with my brother called "Prescription for the Blues."

MR: Yes I have that.

RB: And I don't remember the name of the tune but he gave us the lecture before we started about, "I don't want to hear too many notes, I don't want to hear 16th notes. You know keep your solos short. And Mike was playing away on one tune, burning, with Louis Hayes on drums, Ron Carter on bass, and Horace stopped the take and made us start over. "Too many notes, I told you, I don't want 16th notes."

MR: That's hands on. Yeah.

RB: Yeah he was hands on in that department. Other guys, Art Blakey never said a word but he was very — he knew what he wanted from tune to tune. And there were tunes, like I said, that were specifically open, we could do whatever we wanted. And then he didn't say anything.

MR: What about you? Did you become, when you became a leader of a small group did you find yourself in that situation where you felt that's not really what's needed here?

RB: Yeah. Yeah. I maybe wasn't as hands-on as was Horace but I would — guys would get the idea not to play — so I'd say that, you know "Let's do this tune, let's do it short, we'll stick it in here, we'll stick it in there." And I was pretty good at forming set lists. And Horace, I have to say, was really a big influence on when I started leading bands, probably a bigger influence than just about anybody else, just to rein in certain things so that tunes didn't go on too long. I remember there was a jam session, Bennie was playing and Horace was sitting next to me and he whispered in my ear, "See Bennie's tenor solo is getting long and he's starting to repeat himself." I've never forgot that too, so that still sticks with me.

MR: With all the wonderful tenor players you've played with and continue to play with, is it a challenge for a trumpet player — the very nature of the instruments and how different they are, that you feel compelled to try to keep up with the tenor player? Like especially when you're following their solo? Or does it work the opposite? Like they're playing like this, I'm going to play like this.

RB: Well it's developed as I've matured into more of your — that I'm going to play like this. Because they can play a lot longer without getting tired and just play a lot of notes easier than a trumpet player can. But imagine trying to follow Michael Brecker — that was always — you know other musicians would talk about that, how that was the worst seat in jazz to be the one to follow a Michael Brecker solo. But I just got used to it you know. I had to play what I wanted to play and playing a trumpet is a different instrument even though I remember whenever we had our own dressing room, each warming up, there'd be like twenty guys outside Mike's dressing room with tape recorders. Because Mike always warmed up playing as fast as possible. And I would do my long tones. There was nobody outside my room you know but — as a matter of fact sometimes I do that now, I warm up doing some kind of long tones still, maybe not for as long as I used to, but there are certain days where my chops feel okay, well he would just like to warm up his fingers first. And that kind of works on trumpet. So every once in a while I'll just do that, play a fast tune to start out with.

MR: I can kind of picture the band having a band meeting and saying listen, we all want Michael to solo last from now on.

RB: Well that was discussed quite a bit, not only in our band but you know I remember the Clinton inauguration where he had ten saxophonists play, and you can see it it's on YouTube. Of course Mike was last. I'm sure they had a conversation about that.

MR: Sort of back to the AHA moment question, I think you've actually answered it, but the creation of the Brecker Brothers and that intensity, was there a recording or a person that sort of inspired that? That made you head in that direction?

RB: Well during those times that was kind of bashing — jam sessions, a lot of free music, Coltrane was everyone's idol, and high intensity and playing was the hors d'oeuvres so to speak of the day. So in the early 60s that all sunk in I suppose and of course when Mike discovered Coltrane that was it for him. And I was in the throes, when I first moved to New York, of the Brecker-Liebman-Bob Berg-Steve Grossman complex where they played together quite a bit. And I was in on that so I was around a lot of tenor players, being one of the only trumpets actually, in a lot of the jam sessions. So that was really the kind of style of the day. And you know at the same time I was listening to a lot of R&B and soul music and horn section work.

MR: Would that include James Brown?

RB: Oh sure, sure. I had listened to him as a kid you know, going back to when I was still home in Philly the R&B station — it's unusual — most guys will say that they listened to rock & roll or R&B first and then they caught on to jazz. I did the opposite. I hadn't heard all this other stuff, I was just hearing bebop at home. And one day, and I'd always listened to the radio, the jazz station, WHAT, before I went to sleep but there was another station on the AM dial that was right past the jazz station. I think the AM jazz station was WHAT that was the FM station. But all of a sudden I'm probably 10 or 11 or 12 years old and I heard James Brown and Little Stevie Wonder and all that stuff for the first time and that had a — you know I probably sat up straight in bed. That just hit a nerve. And like I mentioned there was a lot of that style of music around in Philly with that kind of influenced stuff, organ trios, soul jazz, and all the records that came out of Philly they were kind of like Motown. The label that I started talking about was Cameo Parkway. And they were all founded, it was founded by jazz musicians, a guy named Dave Appell was one of the guys who had written charts I think for Jimmie Lunceford, and all these guys I mentioned before there was a — and it was similar to Motown. They'd invent dances, you know it wasn't just coincidence there were so many dances coming out of Philly — the Mashed Potato and the Twist and the Bunny Hop. So in a way looking back on it it was kind of amazing. So there was just a big influence. But by the time I got to New York that was just the style to burn. "Come on man, we're going to bash." And then things kind of as we aged I think now everyone knows how to hold back a little.

MR: So you're probably familiar with the *DownBeat* blindfold tests.

RB: Yeah.

MR: Yeah so I'm going to play a tune for you if you don't mind.

RB: Okay.

[Plays "Slick Stuff"/Brecker Brothers]

MR: That was "Slick Stuff."

RB: Oh. My tune.

MR: Your tune.

RB: Okay. I only heard a little thing. Well that was the general writing style, you know, my style at that point in time where we had had some success with one single that sold a lot called "Sneaking Up Behind You" on the first record, the first Brecker Brother record. Now I have to preface that, and I've told the story many times but I might as well recount it here. I had at one point in my life, and this was after joining Horace and I think it was — let me think for a second here — yeah it was after joining Horace we formed a band called Dreams and Mahavishnu came along and they got Billy Cobham from our band. McLaughlin got Billy and that was the end of Dreams. So I started really seriously thinking about doing my own project for three horns. For myself, my brother, and my old

friend Dave Sanborn who had just moved to New York or he was in Woodstock, he was close by. So that became an impetus for me to write — the cumulative effect of everything that had happened in my life, the music was the cumulative effect of everything that happened in my life both on the jazz side and on the jazz-rock or whatever you want to call it side. So I just got to work composing every day. And eventually we had rehearsals that a lot of the guys from the band Dreams — Will Lee on bass, Don Grolnick on keyboards, Steve Khan on guitar, Chris Parker on drums, me and Mike, Sanborn. We'd rehearse once or twice a week in one of their lofts. A lot of the cats lived in the same building and Grolnick was writing, Steve was writing, it wasn't only my material but I had this thought in mind for this specific thing. Anyway to make a long story short, somehow the word about the band, the stuff we'd been writing, kind of filtered through the grapevine and I got a call from a guy named Steve Becker, who had just signed a production deal with Clive Davis, who had taken over a label called Bell Records and was changing it to Arista Records. Now Clive was a genius in the business. He had signed Dreams to Columbia Records and we did two semi-successful records for him. But this was — and then there was a kind of a scandal that went on and he was innocent but he got fired from Columbia Records so the fact that he was coming back now starting something new was an interesting situation. It was a caveat to his messenger, Steve Becker mentioned that he'll sign you, you won't have to do a demo, we were going to start doing demos, that's what you had to do and try to talk companies into sending it. He said, "He'll sign ya, we've heard about this music, but you have to call the band The Brecker Brothers." And I, you know, duly protested, because I had worked on this music for a couple of years, it was supposed to be my solo record and there are three guys in the front line so if you call it The Brecker Brothers Sanborn's going to look funny. I made up every excuse I could — it'll look like the long lost cousin. But Clive stuck to his game and I agreed, okay, call it The Brecker Brothers. So that was really the birth of the Brecker Brothers and not only was that not quite enough for Clive, I had written nine tunes, among them "Skunk Funk" and tunes in that style. Clive had me to a meeting in his office and he said, "Young man," this guy always knew what he wanted, "you need a single." And I really hit the ceiling, man, 'cause I said look, first of all you're calling it The Brecker Brothers, it's supposed to be my own music, we don't have a single, we just recorded everything I wrote. Basically he said if you don't do a single it ain't comin' out, baby. He was very diplomatic, as he was. And I loved the guy. We would really kind of butt heads, but he was great. So we go in the studio, I explained the situation to the cats, we go to our loft, we jammed up a tune in about four hours. Everybody contributed. It's called "Sneaking Up Behind You." Will thought of a little [sings a melody] sneaking up behind you. He thought of the little words. Mike and I

jammed up a little [scats] I can't even do it anymore, but a little horn line. And the next thing we know, we go in, Clive was in the studio. He loved it. The tune shot to number 2 on the R&B charts. And that's what really sold The Brecker Brothers so to speak because they became really popular and this was in 19 — what year was it — 1975. "Sneaking Up Behind You" and that's what sold the record and started our whole career. And we spent the last — I have to say, this is not great to say, but in a way we spent the next five or six records trying to recreate another hit just to have one more because we saw what it did for us you know. Next thing I know we're headlining or we're opening the show for Chaka Khan or Parliament Funkadelic. It led to amazing things.

MR: I wanted to ask you, you mentioned when you were trying to articulate that thing you said yeah I can't even do this anymore. I wondered if at the time — it's a two part question. First of all the rhythms of the melodies and the whole band, did you have to spend a lot of time figuring out how to notate those things? Was it a chore? [Scats]

RB: Well it was a craft that's the way I looked at it. And once again it came from an interview. I saw, when I was starting to do this Truman Capote was interviewed, the great writer on one of the talk shows. And he was — I'm always interested in other artists' thought process or work process. And he spent a little time in his interview talking about just the craft of writing books, writing literature. The fact that you just have to sit down and do it every day. So it's not — he didn't wait for inspiration. And I think Hemingway was similar. He would write — most writers sit down and do it every day. So I took that to mind and I just spent time sitting at a keyboard or various keyboards and to answer your question, yes writing every note down, trying to figure out the rhythms correctly on score paper. Like everyone this was way before all the electronics. Pencil and paper and score paper and I'd have to figure out all the rhythms and voice everything. And spend time. Sometimes I came up with nothing but the whole thing was that I did spend an hour or two or three every day just sitting there writing stuff, transferring it to cassette tapes — I had the idea of bouncing — I didn't have a four track yet — ping ponging. So I'd record on one cassette player then record over it on another one. I'd lose a lot of whatever the word is.

MR: Yeah. You're not the only one.

RB: Yeah. So that's how eventually by doing that for months at a time over a year I ended up with the nine tunes written relatively correctly. I had my own kind of harmonic ear thing. Because there were still blanks in my music education that I eventually kind of filled up some holes but that's part of the charm of some of that music. The something over something, I didn't know how to figure out some of the scales — they were really melodic minor scales — modes really that I discovered later.

MR: Well the tail end of that piece I played, I don't know if you could hear it that well that Will Lee is doing this incredible, you know, sixteenth note thing and I'm wondering if you wrote that or did you just give him chords and let him go?

RB: That one I'd have to really hear it. If it was towards the end he probably invented — I was pretty specific, I'll say that, with a lot of bass parts. But it sounds like he probably just ran with it.

MR: Ran with it.

RB: And we were a great band. You know if somebody came up with something we'd put it in right away. For instance there's a tune called "Sponge" on the first record. And part of that [scats] was mine but that whole section where there's [scats] a lot of that was Will. Maybe I thought of the changes but the [scats] that was probably Will's. And we were very close. It was really a band of brothers and it got to the point, which was part of the point of the second record which was called The Brecker Brothers Band where it wasn't just my writing. Because these guys were first call guys and they all had ideas so we really tried to make it more of a band and it made it a lot easier on me too so I didn't have to come up with all the music.

MR: With everybody being a first call musician on their axes, is that partly why bands break up?

RB: Well you know we never had that problem but from what I understand if there's big money involved I think that's why bands somehow break up, from what I've heard from other sources and scenes, although I've never really been through that myself. But you hear, once again, stories through the grapevine that money can easily get in the way and people think they're being cheated and they're not getting paid as much as the next guy. But you know if they're great players everyone wants to have his say musically I think, that's a big part of it. And then there are certain bands that know if they did break up full time like The Rolling Stones that they'd probably never get to the point where they have gotten, and they've all done solo records. And both Mike and I did solo records too. I would say his were far more successful than mine, but never — when we got together that was always a more special thing. We could never overcome the Brecker Brothers either name or just the image, no matter what we did alone.

MR: Great. Thank you. We don't have to spend a lot of time on this but can you describe what a typical studio session entailed? How do you get the phone call? How much do you know before you get there? And that kind of thing.

RB: Well that's a tough question to answer because there were — every one was so different. But how do you get the call — it was a lot less dramatic than you think although let me insert this story because it's a good one. We were just talking about this record the other night. Mike and I played on a Frank Sinatra record called "L.A. is my Lady" — a whole

LP with Quincy Jones. It became pretty well known. There's a short film out, I haven't seen it in a long time, and Michael Jackson was planned to show up and they filmed the whole thing. And Mike and I were asked to do, they were going to put a long film out so a couple of guys came over to my apartment, Mike came over with a film crew and one of the questions was how did he get the call? And Mike made up a scenario, well we had gotten a call from — what was that club, I can't think — Juli — Frank's guy in New York, I can't think of his name right now but he had a club under his name. We went over to the club and Frank was there and he said, "Come on guys, take a ride with me in the limo around Central Park I have a new project I want to tell you about." And Mike went into a whole thing, it was all bullshit. Because the real way we got called was there was an answering service who called our answering machine. It was called Radio Registry. You might have heard of it. And that's how 95% of the dates were booked. It was so busy you'd get a call, "Hello? This is Radio Registry are you available 10 'til 5 or 10 to 1 usually — 2 to 5 tomorrow it's for so-and-so or they might mention the artist or the producer, plus an hour overtime if it was a commercial — 10 to 11 with a possible 20 it's for Coca Cola. And you'd go, "Oh Coca Cola, yeah." You never knew. But that's how it worked. It wasn't anywhere near as dramatic as probably people think. Every once in a while there were a couple of other contractors that would call, Sephra Herman — she would call personally sometimes. But that's how we got the call from Frank.

MR: How long did they wait before you called back before they go all right we've got to move on down the line to the next person?

RB: Well they would wait, but you know you were trained, you would check your answer machine or when they had those things you wore on your belt to buzz when they would call. So you would make sure you call them every three or four hours when we were busy. And to further answer your question [inaudible] got called the day before the session. It was that last minute, because people procrastinate, you know writing. So more often than not you really had trouble planning your week because you never were sure when you were going to get a call.

MR: I see.

RB: And one call could — if you get a Coca Cola commercial, I remember one of our successful ones was Maxwell House coffee. They made it into fifty different spots, then you get paid for each spot and if it runs longer than 13 weeks you would get a nice residual check. But you rarely knew what you were going to have to play so you just had to sight read everything. And if it was professionally done you just went in and read the music and thank you, Ma'am. You know. Wham, bam, thank you Ma'am.

MR: And if it was not professionally done then you had to do some scrambling?

RB: Well yeah, we had to do some writing sometimes, and on some very good records. This one always comes to mind, on "Born to Run" the Bruce Springsteen record. It was me, Mike and Sanborn and a great trombone player, Wayne Andre. We showed up at the session and there was music paper on our stands but they were blank. And I think they might have had some bar lines but sometimes they didn't even have bar lines. So it became our job to write a chart. And this was a little out of our — I'll never forget it — "Tenth Avenue Freeze Out" was a little out of our purview I guess might be the word so to speak. It was a little too rock & roll so we weren't coming up with anything. You know I have to say we could jam up anything generally, me, Mike and Dave and Ronnie Cuber and Barry Rogers on trombone. People would do that because they purposely would have us come to the studio and just say, you know we need something here jam it up. But this was one they just didn't have horn parts. So we got about halfway through the tune and there was a lot of commotion in the booth and we weren't really that happy with what we were coming up with but there was commotion in the booth and a guy got on the talkback and said, "Wait a minute, wait a minute, that doesn't sound right, that's no good, that's no good." And it turns out that was Miami Steve Van Zandt, the guitarist and Bruce's good friend. So thankfully he came up with some ideas on that one and we transcribed his ideas and it turned into a chart that we could do the voicings. And it was funny I heard an interview of his and he remembered the same thing but he hadn't known that we were like the first call guys he just thought we were some schlumps that didn't know what we were doing so he felt bad later.

MR: This is very interesting for me because I've played that song with different bands so to hear that thing and remember that I've played [scats]. That's great.

RB: You just never knew what kind of situation — I had another good one in mind, I'm trying to think of it now. Oh for instance — and these all ended up great records. James Taylor — we were close with him at one point, especially Barry was a close friend. And we did now I don't know if I'll remember the record. Of course Mike played on "Don't Let me be Lonely Tonight" it had a wonderful tenor solo. "One Man Dog" it was an album. And James didn't know traditional music writing or rhythms so he wrote the charts on graph paper where each horizontal line was a sixteenth note and each vertical line was a half step. And we had to sit there — but he actually spent all the time doing this. We spent hours transcribing and talking with him to get the charts. But it was amazing that he did it, he figured that out on his own as a way to communicate what he was looking for because he wanted specific horn parts.

MR: I love hearing that kind of information because musicians, schooled musicians sometimes have an attitude, including myself for a long time, about we'll call them "unschooled

musicians." I just — like what you're describing. Sometimes those musicians come up with these things that schooled musicians would not.

RB: Yeah exactly. And at least Mike and I and in a way Barry, we learned on the job and Sanborn, you know we were semi-schooled. You know there were big holes and gaps because I don't think any of us really — when I went to Indiana it wasn't really a developed jazz program yet. I was in the big band, really that was it. I took a traditional theory course but the guy, I don't think he was a good teacher. I didn't get much out of it and he flunked half the class, including me. So I learned from books and from just being on the job. I'd seek out books that I could understand and I always wanted to leave some — it was a conscious decision— how do I put it — to get not too learned. I wanted some kind of unusual stuff that I didn't quite know what it was but it sounded good to me to creep into the music. Maybe that's what we all had in common. And we all had really good ears in our little horn section. Those were the five main guys. There's a record called "The Path" by Ralph McDonald. And that has a really good example where he purposely called me, Mike, Sanborn, Barry, and I think Cuber is on it too. And he said, "Just go in the back room, here's the track, figure out the parts." And we did. Because he had the right guys and it was the right kind of genre. And the parts are really great. They just fit like a glove. So we were good at that too. But the Bruce thing was a little just beyond what we could do well and I think he realized it. So, but it was a great way to make a living though, and we were playing a lot at the same time too, doing gigs at night playing with Hal Galper, playing — eventually we had a club. So I liked being a studio cat. I make no bones about being a session musician. I got a lot out of it. And I worked really hard to, you know, to present my own music at the same time.

MR: Has that scene — I won't say disappeared — but

RB: Well that's the right word.

MR: Okay I'll say it.

RB: It's disappeared in the fact that it's all, you know what you see behind me. I've maybe done 500 sessions here at home with Ada or maybe I'll add a part. But it's all piecemeal. There are very few studios even in New York, there are only some small studios left. One by one all the studios that could actually house a whole group have fallen by the wayside. And everything now is just technology.

MR: But you said — you're pointing behind you and you've done 500 sessions, is that things that they send you the tracks?

RB: Yeah. File sharing. And my wife is an expert at Pro Tools and editing and we sit here and if I'm lucky or if she's lucky we'll get a solo, one or two takes. But more often than not we sculpt solos for records. You know we'll sculpt a solo. I'll play five takes and we'll put together something that sounds kind of perfect to us. That's what they call for, really.

MR: And that's what sculpt means? The term sculpt?

RB: I said like sculpture.

MR: Oh sculpted. Okay.

RB: We sculpt a solo from maybe five different takes. It has to sit right in a track you know or maybe I hold a note too long so we shorten the note alter electronically or the pitch is a little out so we'll change — I mean it's not optimal by any stretch of the imagination. I miss those days when we're all in the studio — at least the horn sections — so it was a lot of overdubbing. Then even during the busy days, well in the first few years you were. When I first started doing studio work they would actually have sessions with everyone in there at the same time. But then four tracks led to eight tracks and then it was better, it was more optimal just to have the rhythm section, call the horns, call the strings later.

MR: Yeah it doesn't seem like there's the adage of we can do this but should we.

RB: Yeah.

MR: Do you ever get mysterious residuals in the mail?

RB: Well I did and occasionally I do. It's hard to tell what it is unless they mark it. But the residuals have been less and less. You know back in the day you could almost live off, honestly, the residuals that you could make particularly from the jingles. I had done more jingle work than Mike because — and this was a conscious decision on his part — he didn't want to be [inaudible] speak. He wanted to concentrate on the tenor saxophone. He even didn't want to play, after a while, soprano. He had one and he played it occasionally and he was a good flute player, but he made that decision you had to really, to be a woodwind studio jingle guy you had to play all the instruments. I just had to play trumpet, flugel and maybe a little piccolo trumpet every now and then.

MR: I see. I'm glad you brought up Ada's name, your wife, and I flashed to this little thing I'm going to run by you. Bassist — I don't know if you know bassist Frank Tate but this goes back 21 years. But I asked him, the question I had for him was what's it like to make a living as a professional musician. And his answer was, "Well I have a wife who has a real job so it's not too bad." So is it challenging for both of you to be in the music business or have you sort of worked out the mechanism?

RB: Well you know like I said, I was lucky to come to New York when I did, wanting to be a freelance player because then there was a lot of work, studio work for those who lent themselves to that. You had to have a certain kind of personality and a certain kind of well rounded way of playing and like different styles of music. I just fit into that mindset pretty easily as did my brother and a lot of the studio musicians. But Broadway was happening — there's problems there now with electronic orchestras taking over, an electronic conductor that when they move their hand the orchestra will move along with them. It's gotten pretty insane. It was also an avid club date scene, so a lot of guys were

working all the time. But now it's a concern. You know you really have to want to write, you really need to write to get some kind of writing checks under your belt, do your own projects, teach and play. It's very hard to make a living just as a player. So things have changed a lot. And I think it's been harder for her. It's been lucky that we work together really well so we've done a lot of this stuff in this room. I was amazed — I started saving some of the sessions we've done just the last couple of years. Usually we have to do a solo, there might be some horn parts, she's gotten really good at writing horn parts. I don't really feel like doing it anymore. She went to Berklee. She'll tell you, and she started arranging and she's great at it, really fast, and gets it into the computer really quickly because I'm very slow at all that stuff. So I'm very lucky to have her. And we just work together really well. But we've done, since — once I started saving the sessions — and a lot of them were for people I don't even know. Some were people I know but we get things from, you know, they find a way to get in touch with me and they send the files via email. We put them in Pro Tools and I put on headphones and off we go. It sounds — but literally since Covid there's been close to 300 different tunes that I've played on. That's just the last two or three years. And each of those are a solo. That's what — it's hard for me to wrap my head around that I have to come up with something each time. I try to play something a little different but it's a challenge. And we always come up with something good because of the technology because like I said we can sculpt it to fit whatever is needed and we're good at that you know because we get all different styles. And I spend a lot of time — I always have — I'm also a big listener so I try to stay up on things that are happening. I can't completely stay up on it because it's so involved now, all the social media, Tik Tok, all the crazy stuff that's happening now to get your music out. I can't begin to even follow that. But I like to read about it and just try to integrate some of it into my head. Maybe it'll have some kind of effect on what we're playing or writing.

MR: Thank you, you just answered one of my questions in front of me, how you keep inspired. Let me run a couple of names by you and see if you have any recollections. You had mentioned Clifford Brown early on. What was it about him that was so distinctive?

RB: Well as a kid just his sound and the melodicism and the passion and the beautiful sound he got out of the trumpet. It was heartfelt. It made me cry. It made my dad cry when we'd hear him play a ballad. I remember, and I was only — he died when I was ten years old so this was early on I grew up with him, at least the last five or six years of his career when he was in Philly dad had all the records. He'd play a ballad and I remember Dad kind of grabbed me and said, "Randy, trumpet's the greatest jazz instrument." And I took that to heart. Because there were also other good trumpet players around Philly although it was more of a tenor player town, but Red Rodney was around, a guy named Burt

Collins, and there were some really good players, and the guy Bobby Mojica was great — he would come over to our house. So I think he was like a friend even though we never met him. I had never heard him play. Dad would go hear him all the time. I wish I could have. I knew his wife very well. After he passed away she was around on the scene quite a bit. But what a sound. I don't think — there are certain things he did that have never been surpassed, just the melodicism, the beauty of everything he played.

MR: Yeah. The "Clifford Brown with Strings" — when he enters in that first cut it's like whoa.

RB: Yeah. It just brings tears to your eyes and it's all in the sound. And he was like that as a man from what I've read and a lot of the cats had substance abuse problems and grew up among other musicians who were all geniuses but had personal problems. He was a straight liver — you know he just went his own way and just had terrible luck in life with his automobile accidents. There was one earlier where he had almost died.

MR: Well this is not maybe an obvious choice but what about Nat Adderley?

RB: Oh I wouldn't say he's an unsung hero but he's another favorite of mine and brought out the early brother thing and that was a big influence that I liked the fact that it was a trumpet and saxophone front line and they were brothers and they seemed to really get along well. And he could play all over the horn and when he was playing good he was up there with the best of them. And also this was interesting to me, that he did a lot of the writing for the band. And that's more or less the way The Brecker Brothers Band ended up even though Mike started writing a lot towards the end. But I kind of furnished the material and Mike took it to places I never could imagine it would go. But I loved Nat's playing. He had a certain soul in his sound, and both those guys had the greatest time feel and chops in their own way. And Nat said the Cannonball started on trumpet but that trumpet didn't work for him.

MR: Well said. I was pleased to read about this project in Poland that came about because of this fellow who was trying to help Michael out. Can you just tell me a little about that?

RB: Well his name is Wlodek Pawlik and he's the head of an exceptional musical family. His brother — I mean his son is a wonderful musician. His wife is also a pianist and composer as is Wlodek. And because they're of Eastern European and Polish descent and our family is also from that area, Mike and people working with him put out feelers to try to get a match for his cancer. It was an area called Tykocin. And our family name on my mother's side is similar, Tykoski, and the rabbi, the local rabbi's last name was Tykoski. So when Wlodek caught wind of this I knew him, I had played several tours with some musicians from a college in the Midwest, I forget the name, Wlodek was the piano player and the wife of the bass player was Polish so that's what the connection was. And the upshot is that Wlodek didn't find a match, Mike never found a match, which is one of the

reasons he went into such decline as his daughter was a half match. They're called alleles and the need a match of I think 12 matches. They tried what was called a Haplo identical transplant but it didn't work. You have to find someone with a match. So Susan, Mike's wife — getting off the subject here — has spent many years trying to get people to register and register their blood just for this because it's still a shortage, particularly minorities. And I don't understand all the science behind it but that's what I remember at the time. And Wlodek and I had been and became very close friends after I've done several projects with him. He's just a wonderful player and writer, a full time composer. Does a lot of films, probably the foremost film composer in Poland. And we did a record and it won a Grammy that year, kind of dedicated to Mike, and went into the story of the whole story about him trying to find a match and lo and behold it won a Grammy. It was a sweet — the name is escaping me right now.

MR: "Jazz Suite Tykocin." (I can't pronounce it).

RB: Tykocin. Yeah. But actually there was one after that. There's one after that. That's the one that won the Grammy and gosh it's terrible I can't remember the name.

MR: "The Jazz Ballad Songbook?"

RB: No keep going, it's right around that time.

MR: Okay.

RB: Oh it'll come to me later.

MR: Okay.

RB: But they all featured Wlodek's writing and the one I'm thinking about we went over and performed it but he didn't like the sound and so we re-recorded — we were talking about this stuff earlier. He re-recorded the orchestra and I had to do all the trumpet parts down here in my pajamas and make it fit over the orchestra. But you know it won a Grammy so I was wearing the right kind of pajamas.

MR: Oh man, the inside stories. Well I've taken up enough of your time today and this has been really delightful. I'll just wrap up with if you had a niece or nephew who felt that they wanted to pursue the jazz life, would you have any words of wisdom for them?

RB: Well I would say that if it's a calling do it. Like it was for me. And it is a calling for hundreds of young musicians. I do a lot of teaching at colleges and I'm in the presence of a lot of fabulous young musicians that are so into being a musician that that's what they're going to do by hook or by crook. And they'll find their way one way or another by teaching, composing, and just playing. Others get a dual degree, you know, in business. That's not a bad idea. A friend of mine, Andy Snitzer, wonderful saxophonist, also got a business degree. These are kind of things I'll counsel young kids. And I try to be honest because now it's harder. You know it's really harder to — there aren't the road bands like there used to be. You really have to forge your own way and keep up with the

social media thing. There's an interesting article in this week's *New Yorker* in fact I have it around, let me see I've got the title here. I just was trying to read it. It's called, and it's for younger people but it's what's happening, "So you want to be a Tik Tok star." And it goes into the details of what's actually going on in the current music business, none of which I have a clue about. But this is really an interesting article 'cause it goes into details — I barely know what an algorithm is but what young players are doing to get their names out there. I don't have a clue, I promise you, but the article — things I do, I like to read and I like to keep up with things, so that's what I'll be doing the rest of the day. It's a long article and it's fascinating to me. So that's more or less — but I always leave musicians saying to have music in your life is a blessing. You know imagine not having it in your life. You know we're set. Just at the push of a button I find happiness. You know so even if you're not going to do it as a professional I urge young people, not only musicians, just to get a handle on the technique behind it. You don't have to be an expert. You don't even have to play but just learn what to listen for. Learn how to follow a tune in bebop. It accesses a part of your brain I think that nothing else does. So I always try to leave with a positive image because man I couldn't live without music. It's as simple as that.

MR: Thank you for that. You're very quotable, Randy.

RB: Well great.

MR: I'm going to pause this and I appreciate it. Congratulations on your career and those Grammys behind you.

RB: Thank you.

MR: You know a lot of trumpet players that I talk to, not just now but for many years, they want to be like Randy.

RB: Well I don't know about that. I've got my own insecurities like everybody else, you should know that too.

MR: Right.

RB: But that's what's part of it. You know I still feel like I'm starting out. I still feel like I'm trying to learn the trumpet. You know I'm just like everyone else, believe me.

MR: All right. Well thanks a lot for your time today.

RB: Thank you, Monk, it's been interesting talking to you, and thank you for all the other videos. I tried to stop watching them because I was playing last weekend and I started thinking too much because I was thinking what Hal was saying or I think what Jerry Bergonzi was saying while I'm trying to improvise. I say stop, stop, I can't — you know so I'm not going to watch any of your videos for a minute here but there's a lot of really great stuff on there. I really learned so much. Thank you.

MR: Thank you. Okay. See you on the flip side.

700 RB: Okay, you got it. Thanks again.